

ATPL EASA STUDY GUIDE | 021 - AIRFRAME & SYSTEMS

Chapter 11: DC Principles, Components & Circuit Protection

Syllabus Source: CAE Oxford (pp. 1-42 (Elec)) | Pass Target: >= 90% AviationExam

1. FUNDAMENTAL DC ELECTRICAL LAWS & UNITS

Direct Current (DC) flows continuously in one direction from positive to negative (conventional current flow) or negative to positive (electron flow). Aeronautical DC systems operate at a standard 28 Volts DC (nominal):

- Ohm's Law: Voltage (V) = Current (I) x Resistance (R). Current is directly proportional to voltage and inversely proportional to resistance.
- Electrical Power: Power (P) = Voltage (V) x Current (I) = I^2 x R = V^2 / R. Measured in Watts (W) or Kilowatts (kW). 1 Horsepower (HP) = 746 Watts.
- Kirchhoff's Current Law (KCL): The algebraic sum of currents entering and leaving any electrical node is zero (Total current in = Total current out).
- Kirchhoff's Voltage Law (KVL): The directed sum of electrical potential differences (voltage) around any closed loop is zero.
- Resistance Combinations: Series: R_total = R1 + R2 + R3 (current identical through all, voltages add). Parallel: 1/R_total = 1/R1 + 1/R2 + 1/R3 (voltage identical across all, currents add; total resistance is always LESS than the smallest individual resistor).

2. CIRCUIT PROTECTION: FUSES VS CIRCUIT BREAKERS (TRIP-FREE)

Electrical conductors are sized according to current rating and allowable voltage drop. Circuit protection devices protect the WIRING against excessive current and fire, not the downstream consumer device:

Device	Operating Principle	Aeronautical Rule & Reset Philosophy
Thermal Circuit Breaker	Bimetallic strip heats up under excessive current (I^2 x R), bends, and trips mechanical latch.	Standard aircraft cockpit protection. Push-pull button with white indicator collar exposed when tripped.
Trip-Free Circuit Breaker	Internal mechanism trips contacts open even if the pilot physically holds or tapes the button in!	MANDATORY CS-25 requirement for flight deck circuit breakers. Prevents crew from overriding an active electrical short-circuit and setting fire to aircraft wiring!
Resetting Policy (SOP)	Commercial airline Standard Operating Procedures strictly regulate resetting tripped CBs.	CRITICAL: Tripped CBs must NEVER be reset in flight unless deemed essential for safe continuation of flight (e.g. landing gear extension), and then ONCE ONLY after a 3-minute cooling period!
Static Dischargers (Wicks)	Conductive carbon fibers mounted at wingtips, elevator tips, and rudder trailing edge.	Discharges accumulated electrostatic precipitation static (P-static) harmlessly into ambient slipstream at low current density, eliminating VHF/HF radio interference.

[!] EXAM TRAP (AVIATIONEXAM) - Trip-Free Circuit Breaker CS-25 Mandate

- Definition: A 'Trip-Free' circuit breaker will open the circuit and trip even if the operating knob or lever is held mechanically in the 'ON' (pushed) position! -

Reason: Guarantees that an electrical short circuit or severe wiring overheat cannot be forced to remain energized by a crew member holding the breaker in.

3. AVIATIONEXAM PRACTICE QUESTIONS (WITH EXPLANATIONS)**Q1: What is the primary purpose of a circuit breaker in an aircraft electrical distribution system?**

[A] To protect the electrical wiring against overheating and electrical fire caused by excessive current [B] To protect the generator against overvoltage [C] To convert AC to DC [D] To regulate bus voltage

[*] OFFICIAL DEFINITION - Detailed Answer Explanation

CORRECT: [A]. Circuit breakers are engineered and sized primarily to protect the aircraft wiring harness from drawing excessive current, overheating, and igniting an in-flight fire.

Q2: What is the defining characteristic of a 'trip-free' circuit breaker as mandated by CS-25 regulations?

[A] It can be reset an unlimited number of times [B] It trips automatically under fault current even if the reset button is held depressed manually [C] It trips with zero time delay [D] It requires no physical reset

[*] OFFICIAL DEFINITION - Detailed Answer Explanation

CORRECT: [B]. A trip-free breaker has an internal linkage that will trip open regardless of whether the pilot holds the external button down, preventing forced overload of shorted wiring.

Q3: What happens to the total resistance of an electrical circuit when additional resistors are connected in PARALLEL?

[A] Total resistance increases [B] Total resistance decreases and is always less than the lowest individual resistor value [C] Total resistance remains constant [D] Total resistance becomes zero

[*] OFFICIAL DEFINITION - Detailed Answer Explanation

CORRECT: [B]. In parallel circuits ($1/R_{tot} = 1/R1 + 1/R2...$), adding parallel pathways provides more routes for current to flow, which always reduces total overall resistance below that of any individual resistor.